GROWING SUCCESS

Assessment, Evaluation and Reporting in Ontario Schools

"Abridged, Annotated Version" (i.e. Cheat Sheet!)

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Introduction (p.1)

Consistency across the province in practice, standards and reporting.
The Ministry of Education's assessment, evaluation, and reporting policy has evolved significantly over the course of the last decade. The document is intended to ensure that policy is clear, consistent, and well aligned across panels and across school boards and schools, and that every student in the system benefits from the same high-quality process for assessing, evaluating, and reporting achievement.

Requires professionalism, dedication and teamwork to implement.

Successful implementation of policy depends on the professional judgement of educators at all levels, as well as on educators' ability to work together and to build trust and confidence among parents and students. It depends on the continuing efforts of strong and energized professional learning communities to clarify and share their understanding of policy and to develop and share effective implementation practices. It depends on creative and judicious differentiation in instruction and assessment to meet the needs of all students, and on strong and committed leadership from school and system leaders, who coordinate, support, and guide the work of teachers.

******These practices are to be implemented in ALL programs and courses.***
The principles and policies outlined in this document apply to assessment, evaluation, and reporting practices in all programs, including Specialist High Skills Major programs, cooperative education, and dual credit programs, and in specific policy areas, such as prior learning assessment and recognition (PLAR) and the secondary school literacy graduation requirement.

Chap.1 FUNDAMENTAL PRINCIPLES (p.6)

The primary purpose of assessment and evaluation is to improve student learning. The following seven fundamental principles lay the foundation for rich and challenging practice. When these principles are fully understood and observed by all teachers, they will guide the collection of meaningful information that will help inform instructional decisions, promote student engagement, and improve student learning.

The Seven Fundamental Principles (p. 6)

******Every planning, assessing, evaluating and teaching practice should hold up to these 7 fundamental principles.***
To ensure that assessment, evaluation, and reporting are valid and reliable, and that they lead to the improvement of learning for all students, teachers use practices and procedures that:

1) are fair, transparent, and equitable for all students;
2) support all students, including those with special education needs, those who are learning the language of instruction (English or French), and those who are First Nation, Métis, or Inuit;
3) are carefully planned to relate to the curriculum expectations and learning goals and, as much as possible, to the interests, learning styles and preferences, needs, and experiences of all students;
4) are communicated clearly to students and parents at the beginning of the school year or course and at other appropriate points throughout the school year or course;
5) are ongoing, varied in nature, and administered over a period of time to provide multiple opportunities for students to demonstrate the full range of their learning;
6) provide ongoing descriptive feedback that is clear, specific, meaningful, and timely to support improved learning and achievement;
7) develop students' self-assessment skills to enable them to assess their own learning, set specific

Chap.2 LEARNING SKILLS AND WORK HABITS GRADES 1 to 12 (p.10)

****** Learning skills are a very important but very separate part of student learning and progress. Marks show WHAT students learned, Learning Skills show HOW they went about their learning process. They MUST be separated, as marks are generated based on curriculum expectations and there are no curriculum expectations on handing an assignment in on time.***
The development of learning skills and work habits is an integral part of a student's learning. To the extent possible, however, the evaluation of learning skills and work habits, apart from any that may be included as part of a curriculum expectation in a subject or course, should not be considered in the determination of a student's grades. Assessing, evaluating, and reporting on the achievement of curriculum expectations and on the demonstration of learning skills and work habits *separately* allows teachers to provide information to the parents and student that is specific to each of the two areas of achievement.

******Teachers must explicitly teach, model and follow-up on these learning skills.***
It is expected that teachers will work with students to help them develop the learning skills and work habits identified in the following table. (See below) For each of the skills and habits, the table provides examples of associated behaviours, which are designed to guide teachers in the instruction, assessment, and evaluation of the learning skills and work habits. The sample behaviours are intended to assist *but not restrict* teachers in their efforts to help students become effective learners, and will look different at the various grade levels.

******Sample Behaviours provide a helpful vocabulary that could be useful on S.A.L. comments.***

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Learning Skills and Work Habits	Sample Behaviours
Responsibility	The student: • fulfils responsibilities and commitments within the learning environment; • completes and submits class work, homework, and assignments according to agreed-upon timelines; • takes responsibility for and manages own behaviour.
Organization	The student: • devises and follows a plan and process for completing work and tasks; • establishes priorities and manages time to complete tasks and achieve goals; • identifies, gathers, evaluates, and uses information, technology, and resources to complete tasks.
Independent Work	The student: • independently monitors, assesses, and revises plans to complete tasks and meet goals; • uses class time appropriately to complete tasks; • follows instructions with minimal supervision.
Collaboration	The student: • accepts various roles and an equitable share of work in a group; • responds positively to the ideas, opinions, values, and traditions of others; • builds healthy peer-to-peer relationships through personal and media-assisted interactions; • works with others to resolve conflicts and build consensus to achieve group goals; • shares information, resources, and expertise and promotes critical thinking to solve problems and make decisions.
Initiative	The student: • looks for and acts on new ideas and opportunities for learning; • demonstrates the capacity for innovation and a willingness to take risks; • demonstrates curiosity and interest in learning; • approaches new tasks with a positive attitude; • recognizes and advocates appropriately for the rights of self and others.
Self-regulation	The student: • sets own individual goals and monitors progress towards achieving them; • seeks clarification or assistance when needed; • assesses and reflects critically on own strengths, needs, and interests; • identifies learning opportunities, choices, and strategies to meet personal needs and achieve goals; • perseveres and makes an effort when responding to challenges.

Chap. 3 PERFORMANCE STANDARDS – THE ACHIEVEMENT CHART (p.16)

All of the Ontario curricula for Grades 1 to 12 comprises ***content standards*** (curriculum overall and specific expectations) and ***performance standards*** (achievement charts). Assessment and evaluation will be based on both the content standards and the performance standards.

******Content standards, curriculum, overall expectations and specific expectations:***
The content standards are the curriculum expectations identified for every subject and discipline. They describe the knowledge and skills students are expected to develop and demonstrate in their class work, on tests, and in various other activities on which their achievement is assessed and evaluated. There are two sets of curriculum expectations – overall expectations and specific expectations. The *overall expectations* describe in general terms the knowledge and skills that students are expected to demonstrate by the end of each grade or course. The *specific expectations* describe the expected knowledge and skills in greater detail. *Taken together, the overall and specific expectations represent the mandated curriculum – the content standards*.

******Achievement charts, purpose and use:***
The performance standards are outlined in the achievement chart that appears in the elementary and secondary curriculum document for every subject or discipline. The achievement chart for each subject/discipline is a standard province-wide guide and is to be used by all teachers as a framework within which to assess and evaluate student achievement of the expectations in the particular subject or discipline. It enables teachers to make consistent judgements about the quality of student learning based on clear performance standards and on a body of evidence collected over time. It also provides teachers with a foundation for developing clear and specific feedback for students and parents.
The purposes of the achievement chart are to:
• provide a common framework that encompasses all curriculum expectations for all subjects/courses across grades;
• guide the development of high-quality assessment tasks and tools (including rubrics);
• help teachers to plan instruction for learning;
• provide a basis for consistent and meaningful feedback to students in relation to provincial content and performance standards;
• establish categories and criteria with which to assess and evaluate students' learning.

******Curriculum expectations are WHAT you teach, but the achievement charts are used to make a rubric, and establish some standards for what the different degrees or levels of achievement within those expectations are. Even with this standard vocabulary for evaluation, professional judgement is more important than ever. For example, what does "with a high degree of effectiveness" versus "a limited degree of effectiveness" mean? Learning to properly use rubrics and achievement charts requires on-going professional development, discussion with colleagues, and moderated marking (NOT shared marking!).***

Categories of Knowledge and Skills (p.17) (K.I.C.A)

******KICA is important when planning your learning goals, and activities. Ensure that you explicitly teach all KICA areas that you will be evaluating. Sometimes we teach the content and assume kids can critically organize, analyse and process, communicate and apply it. This helps us to plan our activities to focus on modeling all of these skills for richer learning.***

The achievement chart identifies four categories of knowledge and skills that are common to both
the elementary and secondary panels and to *all* subject areas and disciplines. The four categories should be considered as interrelated, reflecting the wholeness and interconnectedness of learning. The categories help teachers to focus not only on students' acquisition of knowledge but also on their development of the skills of thinking, communication, and application. The categories of knowledge and skills are as follows:

- **Knowledge and Understanding:** Subject-specific content acquired in each grade/course (knowledge), and the comprehension of its meaning and significance (understanding)
- **Thinking:** The use of critical and creative thinking skills and/or processes
- **Communication:** The conveying of meaning through various forms
- **Application:** The use of knowledge and skills to make connections within and between various contexts

******KICA areas should be balanced in activities and evaluations.***

In all subjects and courses, students should be given numerous and varied opportunities to demonstrate
the full extent of their achievement of the curriculum expectations (content standards) across all four categories of knowledge and skills. Teachers will ensure that student learning is assessed and evaluated in a balanced manner with respect to the four categories, and that achievement of particular expectations is considered within the appropriate categories. The emphasis on "balance" reflects the fact that all categories of the achievement chart are important and need to be a part of the process of instruction, learning, assessment, and evaluation in all subjects and courses.

Levels of Achievement (p.18)

******Levels of achievement are more clearly defined in each subject's achievement chart. In the broadest terms, here are the 4 levels of achievement:***

Level 1 represents achievement that falls much below the provincial standard. The student demonstrates the specified knowledge and skills with limited effectiveness. Students must work at significantly improving learning in specific areas, as necessary, if they are to be successful in the next grade/course

Level 2 represents achievement that approaches the provincial standard. The student demonstrates the specified knowledge and skills with some effectiveness. Students performing at this level need to work on identified learning gaps to ensure future success.

Level 3 represents the provincial standard for achievement. The student demonstrates the specified knowledge and skills with considerable effectiveness. Parents of students

achieving at level 3 can be confident that their children will be prepared for work in subsequent grades/courses.
Level 4 identifies achievement that surpasses the provincial standard. The student demonstrates the specified knowledge and skills with a high degree of effectiveness. *However, achievement at level 4 does not mean that the student has achieved expectations beyond those specified for the grade/course*.

Specific "qualifiers" are used with the descriptors in the achievement chart to describe student performance at each of the four levels of achievement – the qualifier *limited* is used for level 1; *some* for level 2; *considerable* for level 3; and *a high degree of* or *thorough* for level 4. Hence, achievement at level 3 in the Thinking category for the criterion "use of planning skills" would be described in the achievement chart as "[The student] uses planning skills with *considerable* effectiveness".

******Ensuring that a level 3 is consistent from class to class, teacher to teacher, subject to subject, school to school, board to board across Ontario. NO BELL CURVES!!***
This means that teachers assess and evaluate student work with reference to established criteria for four levels of achievement that are standard across the province, rather than by comparison with work done by other students, or through the ranking of student performance, or with reference to performance standards developed by individual teachers for their own classrooms. (There is no expectation that a certain number or percentage of students must be allocated to any one level of achievement.) Criterion-referenced assessment and evaluation ensure that the assessment and evaluation of student learning in schools across the province are based on the application of the same set of well-defined performance standards.

Chap. 4 ASSESSMENT FOR LEARNING AND AS LEARNING (p.27)

"Implementing Assessment FOR Learning and AS Learning in the classroom can be challenging, requiring a transformation in our perception of the teacher-student relationship, as well as new learning about strategies. Success lied in taking an approach that recognizes the interdependence of practices related to Assessment FOR Learning and Assessment AS Learning." (p.36)

Assessment is the process of gathering information that accurately reflects how well a student is achieving the curriculum expectations in a subject or course. As part of assessment *for* learning, teachers provide students with descriptive feedback and coaching for improvement. Teachers engage in assessment *as* learning by helping all students develop their capacity to be independent, autonomous learners who are able to set individual goals, monitor their own progress, determine next steps, and reflect on their thinking and learning.

Teachers will obtain assessment information through a variety of means, which may include formal and informal observations, discussions, learning conversations, questioning, conferences, homework, tasks done in groups, demonstrations, projects, portfolios, developmental continua, performances, peer and self-assessments, self-reflections, essays, and tests. Teachers will ensure that students' demonstration of their achievement is assessed in a

balanced manner with respect to the four categories of the achievement chart (KICA), and that achievement of particular expectations is considered within the appropriate categories. All *specific* expectations must be accounted for in instruction and assessment.

As essential steps in assessment for learning and as learning, teachers need to:
• *plan assessment concurrently* and integrate assessment seamlessly with instruction (downwards design);
• *share learning goals and success criteria with students* at the outset of learning to ensure that students and teachers have a common and shared understanding of these goals and criteria as learning progresses;
• *gather information about student learning before, during, and at or near the end* of a period of instruction, using a variety of assessment strategies and tools;
• *use assessment to inform instruction, guide next steps*, and help students monitor their progress towards achieving their learning goals (gradual release of responsibility);
• *analyse and interpret evidence* of learning;
• *give and receive specific and timely descriptive feedback* about student learning;
• *help students to develop skills of peer and self-assessment.*

******This isn't just a rehash of old practices. This is a new paradigm shift that will fundamentally change elements of your practice.***
The use of assessment to improve student learning and to help students become independent learners
requires teachers and students to acknowledge and enact a fundamental shift in how they perceive
their roles in the learning process.

******The role of the teacher has changed, students are more active, and teachers are more guides.***
In a traditional assessment paradigm, the teacher is perceived as the active agent in the process, determining goals and criteria for successful achievement, delivering instruction, and evaluating student achievement at the end of a period of learning. The use of assessment for the purpose of improving learning and helping students become independent learners requires a culture in which student and teacher learn together in a collaborative relationship, each playing an active role in setting learning goals, developing success criteria, giving and receiving feedback, monitoring progress, and adjusting learning strategies. The teacher acts as a "lead learner", providing support while gradually releasing more and more responsibility to the student, as the student develops the knowledge and skills needed to become an independent learner.

******Assessment For, As and Of are actually most effective when they appear and feel very similar. The only difference is about how much of an active role the students take (gradual release of responsibility) and what the assessment is used for.***
Terms such as *diagnostic*, *formative*, and *summative*, which are used to identify the nature of assessment, have recently been supplemented with the phrases *assessment for learning*, *assessment as learning*, and *assessment of learning*. As Harlen (2006) explains: "Using the terms 'formative assessment' and 'summative assessment' can give the impression that these are

different kinds of assessment or are linked to different methods of gathering evidence. This is not the case; *what matters is how the information is used*. It is for this reason that the terms 'assessment for learning' and 'assessment of learning' are sometimes preferred. The essential distinction is that assessment for learning is used in making decisions that affect teaching and learning in the short term future, whereas assessment of learning is used to record and report what has been learned in the past"

******Assessment For and Assessment As can be formal (Ex: CASI) or informal (Ex: Discussion, table activity, worksheet, etc.). Neither are used for reporting purposes. Only Assessment Of (Evaluation) is used for reporting. See Chap.5)***

Table 4.1 The Purposes of Assessment, the Nature of Assessment for Different Purposes, and the Uses of Assessment Information (p.31)

Purpose of Classroom Assessment	Nature of Assessment	Use of Information
Assessment for learning "Assessment *for* learning is the process of seeking and interpreting evidence for use by learners and their teachers to decide where the learners are in their learning, where they need to go, and how best to get there." (Assessment Reform Group, 2002, p. 2)	***Diagnostic assessment:*** • occurs before instruction begins so teachers can determine students' readiness to learn new knowledge and skills, as well as obtain information about their interests and learning preferences.	The information gathered: • is used by teachers and students to determine what students already know and can do with respect to the knowledge and skills identified in the overall and specific expectations, so teachers can plan instruction and assessment that are differentiated and personalized and work with students to set appropriate learning goals.
	Formative assessment: • occurs frequently and in an ongoing manner during instruction, while students are still gaining knowledge and practising skills.	The information gathered: • is used by teachers to monitor students' progress towards achieving the overall and specific expectations, so that teachers can provide timely and specific descriptive feedback to students, scaffold next steps, and differentiate instruction and assessment in response to student needs.
Assessment as learning "Assessment *as* learning focuses on the explicit fostering of students' capacity over time to be their own best assessors, but teachers need to start by presenting and modelling external, structured opportunities for students to assess themselves." (Western and Northern Canadian Protocol, p. 42)	***Formative assessment:*** • occurs frequently and in an ongoing manner during instruction, with support, modelling, and guidance from the teacher.	The information gathered: • is used by students to provide feedback to other students (peer assessment), monitor their own progress towards achieving their learning goals (self-assessment), make adjustments in their learning approaches, reflect on their learning, and set individual goals for learning.
Assessment of learning "Assessment *of* learning is the assessment that becomes public and results in statements or symbols about how well students are learning. It often contributes to pivotal decisions that will affect students' futures." (Western and Northern Canadian Protocol, p. 55)	***Summative assessment:*** • occurs at or near the end of a period of learning, and may be used to inform further instruction.	The information gathered: • is used by the teacher to summarize learning at a given point in time. This summary is used to make judgements about the quality of student learning on the basis of established criteria, to assign a value to represent that quality, and to support the communication of information about achievement to students themselves, parents, teachers, and others.

Developing Learning Goals (p.33)

Assessment *for* learning and *as* learning requires that students and teachers share a common understanding of what is being learned. Learning goals clearly identify what students are expected to know and be able to do, *in language that students can readily understand*. **Teachers develop learning goals based on the curriculum expectations** and share them with students *at or near the beginning of a cycle of learning*. Teachers and students come to a common understanding of the learning goals through discussion and clarification during instruction.

******POST LEARNING GOALS! Use of process walls and anchor charts that the dignitaries like to see.*** ☺

Identifying Success Criteria (p.33)

Success criteria describe in specific terms what successful attainment of the learning goals looks like. When planning assessment and instruction, teachers, guided by the achievement chart for the particular subject or discipline (see Chapter 3), identify the criteria they will use to assess students' learning, as well as what evidence of learning students will provide to demonstrate their knowledge and skills. The success criteria are used to develop an assessment tool.
******Success Criteria are developed based on the curriculum expectations and learning goals. They have qualifiers that assign degree of achievement, and are modeled after level 3 expectations. If the student can read that criteria and apply that truthfully to their work, they will be able to achieve a level 3. A checklist does not require qualifiers and does not have to relate to the curriculum. They are usually norms you want in a task that relate to the structure, format or activity. Both will improve student achievement, and both are necessary for best learning.***
(Success criteria: "I can clearly and logically organize my ideas in a paragraph")
(Checklist: "I have a topic sentence, body, and concluding sentence in my paragraph")

Eliciting Information About Student Learning (p.34)

******Great examples of activities that provide rich Assessment FOR information:***
Teachers use a variety of assessment strategies to elicit information about student learning. These strategies should be triangulated to include observation, student-teacher conversations, and student products. Teachers can gather information about learning by:
• designing tasks that provide students with a variety of ways to demonstrate their learning;
• observing students as they perform tasks;
• posing questions to help students make their thinking explicit;
• engineering classroom and small-group conversations that encourage students to articulate what
they are thinking and further develop their thinking.

Teachers then use the information gathered to adjust instruction and provide feedback. Homework tasks designed to help students practise and consolidate new learning can also provide assessment information that both teachers and students can use to adjust instruction and focus learning.

Providing Descriptive Feedback (p.34)

Feedback provides students with a description of their learning. The purpose of providing feedback is to reduce the gap between a student's current level of knowledge and skills and the learning goals. According to Davies (2007, p. 2), descriptive feedback "enables the learner to adjust what he or she is doing in order to improve." **Ongoing descriptive feedback linked specifically to the learning goals and success criteria is a powerful tool for improving student learning** and is fundamental to building a culture of learning within the classroom. As the teacher provides feedback, and as the student responds to it, the assessment information gathered is used to improve learning as well as instruction. Multiple opportunities for feedback and follow-up **are planned during instruction to allow for improvement in learning prior to assessment of learning** (evaluation). The focus of the feedback is to encourage students to

produce their best work by improving upon their previous work and, at the same time, to teach them the language and skills of assessment, so they are able to assess their own learning and that of their peers (Assessment AS Learning).

Developing Student Self-Assessment and Peer Assessment Skills (p.35)

******Must model and teach self-assessment and meta-cognition explicitly!***

Teachers help students develop their self-assessment skills by modelling the application of success criteria and the provision of descriptive feedback, by planning multiple opportunities for peer assessment and self-assessment, and by providing descriptive feedback to students about the quality of their feedback to peers.

******Collaborative small-group work is ideal for Assessment AS Learning opportunities as part of the Gradual Release of Responsibilities.***

Group work provides students with opportunities to develop and practise skills in peer and self-assessment and gives teachers opportunities to model and provide instruction related to applying success criteria, providing descriptive feedback, and developing collaborative learning skills. Teachers and students can use assessment information obtained in group situations to monitor progress towards learning goals and to adjust the focus of instruction and learning.

Chap. 5 EVALUATION (p.35)

Evaluation refers to the process of judging the quality of student learning on the basis of established performance standards (see Chapter 3) and assigning a value to represent that quality. Evaluation accurately summarizes and communicates to parents, other teachers, employers, institutions of further education, and students themselves what students know and can do with respect to the **overall curriculum expectations**. Evaluation is based on assessment *of* learning that provides evidence of student achievement at strategic times throughout the grade/course, often at the end of a period of learning.

******Teach specific expectations, Evaluate Overall expectations***

For Grades 1 to 12, **all** (overall and specific) curriculum expectations must be accounted for in **instruction and assessment**, but *evaluation focuses on students' achievement of the* ***overall expectations***. A student's achievement of the overall expectations is evaluated on the basis of his or her achievement of related specific expectations. The overall expectations are broad in nature, and the specific expectations define the particular content or scope of the knowledge and skills referred to in the overall expectations. **Teachers will use their professional judgement to determine which specific expectations should be used to evaluate achievement of the overall expectations, and which ones will be accounted for in instruction and assessment but not necessarily evaluated.**

Evidence of Student Achievement for Evaluation

Evidence of student achievement for evaluation is collected over time from three different sources – *observations*, *conversations*, and *student products*. Using multiple sources of evidence increases the reliability and validity of the evaluation of student learning.
"Student products" may be in the form of tests or exams and/or assignments for evaluation. Assignments for evaluation may include rich performance tasks, demonstrations, projects, and/or essays. *To ensure equity for all students, assignments for evaluation and tests or exams are to be completed, whenever possible, under the supervision of a teacher*.

Assignments for evaluation must not include ongoing homework that students do in order to consolidate their knowledge and skills or to prepare for the next class. Assignments for evaluation may involve group projects as long as each student's work within the group project is evaluated independently and assigned an individual mark, as opposed to a common group mark. **The evaluation of student learning is the responsibility of the teacher and must not include the judgement of the student or of the student's peers.**

Determining A Report Card: Grades 1 to 12 (p.39)

******Marks are not generated by averging, but my looking at all of the Assessment OF in a Term, and identifying the most consistent level of achievement, paying special consideration given to richer tasks, and more recent work.***

Teachers will take various considerations into account before making a decision about the grade to be entered on the report card. The teacher will consider all evidence collected through observations, conversations, and student products (tests/exams, assignments for evaluation). The teacher will consider the evidence for all the tests/exams and assignments for evaluation that the student has completed or submitted, the number of tests/exams or assignments for evaluation that were not completed or submitted, and the evidence of achievement that is available for each overall expectation for a subject in a particular grade or course. **In addition, the teacher will consider that some evidence carries greater weight than other evidence; for example, some performance tasks are richer and reveal more about students' skills and knowledge than others. Teachers will weigh all evidence of student achievement in light of these considerations and will use their professional judgement to determine the student's report card grade.** The report card grade represents a student's achievement of overall curriculum expectations, as demonstrated to that point in time.

Teachers will benefit from leadership by the principal to ensure that there is a common understanding among all staff about the process for determining the final grade. The principal will work with teachers to ensure common and equitable grading practices that follow ministry policy and board guidelines.